



BB World app store improved

BlackBerry made a few significant changes to its BlackBerry World app store in order to improve search and discovery of its 80,000+ games and apps

Ubuntu goes to China

The Chinese Ministry of Industry and IT is basing their national reference architecture for standard OSes on Ubuntu. Great success for Canonical!

Insights from Acer

In the post-PC era, what's relevant, what's not. Here's an OEM's perspective

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The PC is being redefined. We caught up with Acer India's Director of Product Management, Mr. Saji Kumar, to check the pulse of PC OEMs.

Analysts predict tablets to outsell laptops this year, and a bad year for PC manufacturers. Is Acer poised to exploit this trend?

We must understand IT penetration in India in only at 6-7 per cent when compared to other developing countries such as China which is 20%. So this leaves the IT market to explore all those untouched virgin territories. In spite of low consumer sentiments we completely believe there is a massive opportunity for the PC market to grow. The execution of projects undertaken by the Tamil Nadu and Uttar Pradesh government for over 9 lakh laptops and 1.5 million laptops respectively is a classic example of the existing opportunities. The tablet PC market in India is one of the fastest growing markets around the globe gaining acceptance from customers from multiple segments. Acer's ICONIA B1 marks Acer's foray into the budget tablet category while the Windows 8 based Iconia W510 launched a few months back has gained immense traction among consumers as well as corporate customers. In the past, we have already launched tablet PCs on both Android and Windows platform. In the year ahead, we have plans to make further additions to our tablet portfolio.

Is it inevitable that all PC manufacturers will have to diversify or die a slow death?

With proliferation of devices in the marketplace, the PC landscape and consumer buying patterns have witnessed a series of changes. In such a scenario, it is important to continuously expand the product range to offer more choice and convenience to the consumers.



Mr. Saji Kumar -Director, Product Management, Acer India

How has Microsoft's new OS affected user interest and PC sales volumes?

Microsoft launched Windows 8 Operating system at a time when the overall market was moving towards 'touch'. However with limited SKUs available in the marketplace, consumers had little choice to choose from. There has been a significant increase in the variety of touch-enabled notebooks in the marketplace. We were one of the first OEM brands to introduce a suite of Windows 8 products during the launch. We have beefed up our product portfolio to address the requirements of all cross sections of consumers. Consumers have just been introduced to this new OS. However, there has been a gradual yet steady acceptance of Windows 8 OS, consumers and the enterprise segments have been adopting touch-based notebooks. We are confident of this form factor gaining steady ground.

Would you say that AIOs are the future of the traditional desktop?

Desktop computing has transformed tremendously and the all-in-one product cat-

egory has gained significant prominence. The AIOs are undoubtedly the future of the traditional consumer desktop PC category. While there will be a continued market for the traditional desktops, we are confident that the AIO product category will witness traction in the coming quarters. All in One product segment is a fairly new category that acts as a one-stop solution for consumers looking at PC consumption and entertainment in a home environment. We are confident that over a period of time there will be evolved variants of this particular form factor in the marketplace.

What will be Acer's focus this year?

With our recent foray into the budget tablet segment and AIO segment, we will be looking at these product categories more closely. In the coming months, we plan to add more offerings to the existing portfolio. We have also beefed up our touch range of notebook products and you will see more such flavour of Notebooks coming from our stable this year. Moreover, in the commercial segment, our focus will continue to be on traditional desktops and notebooks.

In the next five years, what will dictate the flow of innovation? Will mobile devices drive innovation, or will PC's fightback?

While the emergence of multiple form factors presents a major change in personal computing, the traditional desktop will continue to gain acceptance from certain verticals such as Govt., Education, BFSI, etc. As mobility becomes more of a requirement for consumers across the globe, computing devices will become even more compact. Introduction of new technologies in both the hardware and software platform will continue to enhance customer experience. Today consumers are inclined to using one computing device that offers multiple-functional usage and enhancing user experience. **■**